we should not encourage sycophants. We should foster an intellectual landscape featuring honest analysis and discussion. When person X praises the policymaker and person Y criticizes the policymaker, it is more useful for the policymaker to meet person Y and understand the logic of the criticism. This conversation may result in course corrections.

In an environment where critics are attacked and harmed, these feedback loops will be harmed. The government will then encourage sycophants, who will always praise the government. Mid-course corrections will not take place. Lacking in the support system of criticism, the government will stumble from one mistake to the next.

Authoritarian regimes, that neglected the value of feedback, have repeatedly failed in the human experience of thousands of years.

Conflict in the public domain is the healthy state

Authoritarian regimes look well organized and powerful, like the clean formations in a military parade. There is a great leader, and everyone is deferential to the positions of the great leader and the inner circle of power. Once a position is taken, everyone falls in line, in public, with a great deal of flattery. The great leader is incapable of making mistakes and must always be praised. There are disagreements and conflicts, of course, but they take place outside the public gaze, and tend to degenerate into pure power play.

> *No government can be long secure without a formidable opposition.*
>
> Benjamin Disraeli

> *The absence of a true opposition has led to the rapid deterioration of democracy into a kind of totalitarianism.*
>
> C. Rajagopalachari [2]

In contrast, democracies *look* messy. They are riven with debate, dissension, and a tug of war. Power is dispersed across many individuals and many